

CITY OF THE INCA

The city of Machu Picchu lay abandoned in the Andes Mountains for more than four hundred years, its location known only to a few local people. The hidden haven was built in the mid-15th century by a South American people called the Inca, who may have used it as a religious center or royal retreat.



The Inca Empire

The land controlled by the Inca ran along the mountainous western coast of South America. The Inca were highly organized and built a vast road network to connect their cities.



Inca emperor

The Inca leader was called the *Sapa Inca*. This *Sapa Inca* was called Pachacuti. Machu Picchu was one of his estates.



Khipu

The Inca didn't have a writing system. They recorded information using knotted strings called *khipus*. No one can read *khipu* today, which means most of what we know about the Inca comes from archaeology.



Hiram Bingham

In 1911, US explorer Hiram Bingham was in the Andes Mountains, searching for a lost city called Vilcabamba. Local people led him to Machu Picchu instead, and Bingham shared the story of the city with the rest of the world.



Excavating the city

In 1912, archaeologists began clearing the thick plants that had grown over Machu Picchu. They took thousands of photographs and uncovered artifacts that they took away to the US.

